

"When man is struggling for freedom, why should poetry not be freed from the confines of metre?"

FREEDOM'S VERSE

He was not only the pioneer of blank verse, but also a lyricist and a great contemporary prose writer. An unrepentant lifelong experimentalist, he changed forever the destiny of Hindi poetry.



■ By Kedarnath Singh

Even though literature is not the realm for anticipatory forecasts, I am tempted to think that Suryakant Tripathi Nirala, who has been a beacon of light for me, will always have the power to move the masses. A new generation may, in fact, discover new meanings in his poetry and prose, something that may have been missed, or even overlooked, in the last century. Nirala was a *chhayavadi* (romantic) poet, but at the same time a revolutionary realist just like the Russian romantic poet, Alexander Pushkin. The essence of his creativity was such that it seemed to complete one circular movement in a poem, and in the very next it could break that circle, exploring entirely new directions.

But Nirala was not only a poet. He was also a creative prose writer of remarkable innovation, with some of his later prose already acquiring the status of classics. His contemporary Sumitra Nandan Pant perhaps summed him up best, saying he broke *chhand ke bandh tatha roorhiyon ke bandhan* (the shackles of rhyme as well as of superstition). Spanning the literary firmament from the third to the sixth decade of the last century, it is difficult to find

S. Tripathi Nirala

Poet 1896-1961